

characters to gain the upper hand. An antagonist might have a soft spot for a certain person, for instance, and find it impossible to go through with her plan if it places him in danger, or she might be prone to rages and poor decisions if she's taunted in public. Just like character weaknesses make for more interesting characters, antagonist weaknesses make opponents more than just cookie-cutter villains.

Indeed, although it's tempting to make a story's antagonists pure evil, remember that every "villain" needs a reason for what they do — what's at stake for them? A marauding chimerical beast might simply be hungry and searching for food, for instance, while a Dauntain high school principal might be crushing the hopes of Dreamers from a warped but sincere desire to "protect" them from the uncertainties of the creative job market. These reasons don't make such enemies less fearsome, but they do make for more relatable foes, and potentially open new avenues to tackling those threats rather than just grabbing weapons and rushing right in. Some antagonists might be "good guys" who are just on the opposite side of the characters, maybe even friends or allies who don't like opposing the group but find they have no choice.

Likewise, Storytellers should consider the stakes for villains in much the same way they consider the stakes for characters. An antagonist's stakes determine how far she will go to achieve her goals, not to mention when she's likely to retreat and regroup (or surrender). Is a teen bully really going to kill — or die — just to make her changeling girlfriend the prom queen? Or is she likely to give up after the characters dish out some public embarrassment? Remembering that most villains aren't video game enemies who simply fight until they're destroyed opens up possible alternative solutions to defeating them, not to mention makes those fanatics who *are* willing to kill and die for their cause rare and genuinely terrifying.

Creating antagonists that are less "evil" and more simply at cross purposes with the characters is a good way to introduce stories with complex moral or ethical choices, as simply destroying the opposition may not be right or even desirable. Even against really despicable villains, sometimes the most direct confrontation options simply aren't viable, requiring characters to explore different avenues to handling problems rather than just throwing punches or casting cantrips until an enemy is vanquished.

Climax

Although roleplaying games do not have predetermined endings like many other forms of gaming, that doesn't mean the individual stories should simply go on and on forever. While chronicles may last many years, it's important for Storytellers to have an idea how each story will end, and to work toward an appropriate ending so that the story can have a satisfactory resolution for the players.

This might seem like contradictory advice, but it's actually quite necessary to avoid having stories stagnate or meander as they stretch out over long periods of time. A story that never resolves winds up being hard to engage with, because it goes against every other type of story the players have ever encoun-

